

I went back to Paris from Madrid for another few days because I was flying out of Charles de Gaulle airport. My last day in Paris, I went to a lesbian bar with a girl I was sort of dating's ex who was also visiting the city (classic queer women triangulation). Leaving the bar, I reached into my purse and realized my wallet had been stolen. I had my passport in my bag, so I could feasibly get home, but I'd lost my credit and debit cards, \$80 in cash, and a pair of earrings I'd bought in New Orleans that had sentimental value. We retraced my steps and found nothing.

My friend and I went to the local police station to report my wallet stolen, but they were no help. (I imagine the French police blowing cigarette smoke in my face, but I know that didn't happen.) I filed a report, but it was useless. I had to get on a plane that next morning. My friend gave me some money for a couple of taxis. I went back to my Airbnb, packed my things, and headed straight to the airport. I didn't want to spend another minute on the Paris streets, which now seemed like a sobering sinkhole for money.

I got on my early-morning flight and did not have money for food the whole trip. I was starving. When I got to JFK, I realized I didn't have my MetroCard to get home. I called my ex-boyfriend, the comedy writer Josh Gondelman, an actual angel on planet Earth, and begged him to come pick me up at the airport in his car. On the way home, he was way too gentle with me but chided me a little on my choices. (He should have been way madder than he was. We'd broken up in April, and here he was picking me up from the airport after I'd been reckless.) I went to the bank and got a temporary debit card, and eventually I replaced the things in my wallet—except for the cash and earrings. Emotionally and financially, I was at my lowest.

I went back to my day job and took on more hours. Eventually I left to take a higher-paying full-time job with much-needed benefits at the *Daily Dot*, a newsy site where I was working as a reporter instead of as a blogger, thus finally putting my expensive journalism degree to use. DD paid more, and I desperately needed a higher salary.

I still had credit card debt from my mania, but I never thought about it. I figured it was a problem that future-me could deal with. I was convinced I was special and was going to succeed so wildly at this young age that the debt didn't